

PROOF OF REPENTANCE

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: 2 Corinthians 7:8-11 (KJV) *“For though I made you sorry with a letter, I do not repent, though I did repent: for I perceive that the same epistle hath made you sorry, though it were but for a season. ⁹Now I rejoice, not that ye were made sorry, but that ye sorrowed to repentance: for ye were made sorry after a godly manner, that ye might receive damage by us in nothing. ¹⁰For godly sorrow worketh repentance to salvation not to be repented of: but the sorrow of the world worketh death. ¹¹For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves, yea, what indignation, yea, what fear, yea, what vehement desire, yea, what zeal, yea, what revenge! In all things ye have approved yourselves to be clear in this matter.”*

INTRO: The book of Second Corinthians is Paul the Apostles second letter to the Corinthian church. The Corinthian church was located in the ancient city of Corinth and the moral climate of the city of Corinth was such, that by the most conservative of estimates, it was a city of great wickedness. The wickedness of the city caused it to be very fertile soil for the seed of the Gospel! Romans 5:20 (KJV) *“... Where sin abounded, grace did much more abound.”*

Paul was the founder of the Corinthian church, having established it on one of his missionary journeys. The Apostle spent a great deal of time in the city of Corinth declaring the good news of Jesus Christ, but he also expended much effort and energy giving written instructions to these people on how to order their personal lives, as well as their religious activities.

Paul begins verse eight of our text by saying, ***“for though I made you sorry with a letter...”*** This letter was also referred to in [2 Corinthians 2:4](#) (KJV) ***“For out of much affliction and anguish of heart I wrote unto you with many tears; not that ye should be grieved, but that ye might know the love which I have more abundantly unto you.”***

There are two schools of thought with regard to this seemingly mysterious “letter.” One school of thought is that there was a very severe “letter” from Paul to the Corinthian Church that was somehow lost and never recorded. The second school of thought is that he is referring to the book of First Corinthians. After much study I am inclined to agree with this second scenario. The reason I am inclined to agree with the latter of these two opinions is because of what Paul said in his first letter to the Corinthian Christians! He addresses:

- 1) Divisiveness in the Church...
- 2) The source of the divisiveness...
- 3) The absence of discipline in the church...
- 4) Civil litigation between members of the body of Christ...
- 5) The moral decline of members of the church...

- 6) Marriage and divorce...
- 7) The eating of food sacrificed to idols. Etc...

This kind of a letter is no big deal unless you are a guilty party. If you are a guilty party, this kind of preaching will make you do one of two things, get mad, or repent. An elderly preacher once told me, *“If you throw a rock into a pack of dogs the only one who barks is the one who got hit!”*

This brings us to our subject matter for this message, which is the importance of repentance. The doctrine of repentance is a very important doctrine in your Bible. One hundred and ten times the word repentance or some form of the word is used in the Bible.

In our text, in four verses the Apostle Paul uses:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The word *“repent”* two times...
- The word *“repented”* one time...
- The word *“repentance”* two times...
- The word *“sorry”* four times...
- The word *“sorrow”* two times...
- The word *“sorrowed”* two times...

Now what message do you think the Apostle Paul was trying to drive across here?

I want us to look at the word repentance in hopes that we can gain a proper understanding of its meaning in our day to day lives. **Repentance**, as it is used here comes from the Greek word *“metanoia”* (met-an-oy-ah), meaning **compunction for guilt including**

reformation. The word *compunction* means anxiety arising from the awareness of guilt. To reform means to amend or improve by change or form, or removal of faults or abuses.

I think we could safely say that repentance means that we see where we have been wrong, acknowledge it, and set out with renewed passion never to repeat the failure again.

The words “*I’m sorry*” seems to fall effortlessly from the lips of this culture but I wonder how much real repentance there is in this world, or better yet in the church?

Paul said “*Godly sorrow brings about repentance.*” Repentance is not a popular topic, but I can assure you that it is an important one; in fact, one cannot get saved without repenting. If we cannot get saved without repentance, we certainly cannot live an overcoming life without walking in repentance and forgiveness.

Repentance has become a lost sermon of the Church of this modern hour, but it was on the top of Paul’s list of candy sticks to preach.

There is much debate on the topic of what true repentance is. Some do not believe in dry eyed confessions, they believe you must shed tears to repent and be saved. I’ve seen people shed enough tears to generate electricity for this town for several days, but they still don’t live right. Some people believe that

you must shake a preacher's hand, or join the Church to be saved. I've seen people do both but it didn't change their lives. So what is the proof of repentance?

Paul says in verse eleven that there are seven attributes that will assimilate themselves in the lives of those who truly repent. I want us to look very closely at them because I believe they prove that one has repented.

I. WHAT CAREFULNESS...

2 Corinthians 7:11 (KJV) ***"For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you..."*** The word **carefulness**, as it is used here, comes from the Greek word "*spoude*" (spoo-day), and means **eagerness or earnestness**.

Think about it; when we have been wrong or sinned and that sin has been discovered; we have owned up to our sin and made the proper apologies because we are truly sorry; does it not make one far more careful or cautious when one approaches the tempting point of that particular failure or sin the next time?

One of the ways we prove we have truly repented is that we will make things right: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- With God...
- With others...
- With ourselves...

Paul knew what it meant to sin against the Lord! 1 Timothy 1:15 (KJV) ***“This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am chief.”*** Paul was painfully aware that he had spent a great deal of his life disappointing the Lord with his lifestyle but when he was convicted by the Holy Spirit he repented, and became extremely careful never to repeat his past failures.

This world's system say's, if you've done something wrong and were unfortunate enough to get caught: Just say you are sorry... **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Pay the minimum penalty...
- Move on with your life...
- Sin is really no big deal...

Most of the sorrow that the world's system produces is for having been caught, not for the wrong which has been committed.

Our justice system is a prime example of this short sighted philosophy. Violent criminals are being allowed early release not because they have been rehabilitated, but because of good behavior. Anyone can be on good behavior for a short period of time but real repentance will make one careful or eager to do what ever is necessary to make sure we never repeat that same mistake again. Carefulness is the proof that one has repented.

Notice what happened when King David's sin with Bathsheba was exposed by the prophet Nathan. [2 Samuel 12:13](#) (KJV) "*And David said unto Nathan, I have sinned against the LORD...*" In this verse you can hear the disappointment in David's voice and his sorrow is over having disappointed the LORD who made him King! David's attitude here is very different from the general population as well as that of the church crowd. No one had to drag the truth out of him, he just owned up to his own failure. This would be a different world if everyone were as fourth coming as David was.

David's prayer of repentance before God is recorded in [Psalm 51:1-19](#) (KJV) "*Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy loving-kindness: according unto the multitude of thy tender mercies blot out my transgressions. Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin. For I acknowledge my transgressions: and my sin is ever before me. Against thee, thee only, have I sinned, and done this evil in thy sight: that thou mightest be justified when thou speakest, and be clear when thou judgest. Behold, I was shapen in iniquity; and in sin did my mother conceive me. Behold, thou desirest truth in the inward parts: and in the hidden part thou shalt make me to know wisdom. Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean: wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow. Make me to hear joy and gladness; that the bones which thou hast broken may rejoice. Hide thy face from my sins, and blot out all mine iniquities. Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me. Cast me not away*

from thy presence; and take not thy holy spirit from me. Restore unto me the joy of thy salvation; and uphold me with thy free spirit. Then will I teach transgressors thy ways; and sinners shall be converted unto thee. Deliver me from blood guiltiness, O God, thou God of my salvation: and my tongue shall sing aloud of thy righteousness. O Lord, open thou my lips; and my mouth shall shew forth thy praise. For thou desirest not sacrifice; else would I give it: thou delightest not in burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise. Do well in thy good pleasure unto Zion: build thou the walls of Jerusalem. Then shalt thou be pleased with the sacrifices of righteousness, with burnt offering and whole burnt offering: then shall they offer bullocks upon thine altar.” Twelve times in nineteen verses

David takes personal responsibility for his failures. He never points a finger of accusation at Bathsheba, the devil, or anyone else; he takes full responsibility for his failures. The reason for this is that David truly repented! [True repentance accepts full and final responsibility for wrong behavior.](#)

David's repentance is evidenced by the fact that he was careful to never repeat his mistake again. What better proof could a person offer that they have truly repented, than to be careful to stay as far away from sin as one can possibly live?

The reason God was able to identify David as having a heart like Himself is that not one time do you ever see David making this mistake again.

Do I think he was ever tempted again? Yes! Do I think the opportunity was presented for him to fall into this kind of sin again? Yes! Why did he not fall into this sin repeatedly? David repented, and his repentance brought about extreme caution, and carefulness, he was determined to prove his repentance by not allowing himself to repeat his failure.

The most wonderful words of this horrible dilemma can be found in [2 Samuel 12:13](#) (KJV) “...*And Nathan said unto David, The LORD also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die.*”

Were there consequences to pay with regard to David's sin? Yes, the child born to this unholy union died. Never forget, [sin always leaves a scar on the soul!](#) **(LEAVE THIS SLIDE UP THROUGHOUT THE REMAINDER OF THE SERMON AND THE ALTAR SERVICE)**

The real story here is that Kind David repented, was forgiven, and became very careful never to repeat his failure again, thus God was able to use him mightily.

If we will repent of our sins today, God will forgive us as well. But I caution all of us, once we have repented, we should be careful not to make the same mistakes repeatedly.

II. WHAT CLEARING OF YOURSELVES...

[2 Corinthians 7:11](#) (KJV) “*For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves.*” The word [clearing](#) comes from the Greek

word “*apologia*” (ap-ol-og-ee-a) which means to answer for oneself with a plea, so as to completely confess. In other words, to enter a plea of guilt so comprehensive that there would be nothing for the judge or jury to discover at a later date.

This worlds system encourages us: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To hide everything we can...
- Not to admit to anything that has not been proven against us...
- Not to volunteer any incriminating information...
- Manipulate the system to the point of clearing oneself...

No matter how many “*not guilty*” verdicts are rendered by this worlds system, they will never clear the conscience of the guilty. (Cain killed Able; Able’s blood “*Cried out from the ground.*”)

The philosophy of the world presents itself in every sector of our society. Sadly, this philosophy has also found its way into the church! The all important question seems to be, “*how can save face?*”

This philosophy is very damaging and damning because it leaves no room for a person to clear, or come clean with: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Oneself...
- Ones God...
- Ones Family...
- Ones government...

The soul of a man cries out for a gift of amnesty and oblivion! Each of us have a need to clear ourselves before God and man. Proof that this is true can be found in the fact that a couple years ago the IRS gave amnesty for anyone who wanted to amend their returns, or file returns for missing years. Millions responded!

If anyone ever had a need to clear themselves before God, Paul by his own admission did! [1 Timothy 1:15](#) (KJV) ***“This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am chief.”*** Before Paul was saved his name was Saul, and he was attempting to build a career on persecuting the Church. He was present at the stoning of Stephen; in fact, he held the coats for the executioners while this faithful servant of the Lord was murdered. [Acts 7:58](#) (KJV) ***“...and the witnesses laid down their clothes at a young man's feet, whose name was Saul.”***

By his own admission, Saul was a poor excuse for a human being, but something revolutionary happened on the road to Damascus. [Acts 9:3-8](#) (KJV) ***“And as he journeyed, he came near Damascus: and suddenly there shined round about him a light from heaven:***

And he fell to the earth, and heard a voice saying unto him, Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me? And he said, Who art thou, Lord? And the Lord said, I am Jesus whom thou persecutest: it is hard for thee to kick against the pricks. And he trembling and astonished said, Lord, what wilt thou have me to do? And the Lord said unto him, Arise, and go into the city, and it shall be told thee what thou must do. And the men which journeyed with him stood speechless, hearing a voice, but seeing no man. And Saul arose from the earth; and when his eyes were opened, he saw no man: but they led him by the hand, and brought him into Damascus.” Between this event on

the road to Damascus, and a three day stay on Straight Street in the home of Judas and his family, something life changing happened to Saul! We might be surprised what a little living on Straight Street can do for us!

Saul cleared himself before God and man! Can you imagine the confession service that must have taken place on Straight Street? (My experience on an Airplane from Texarkana to Detroit; I confessed things I had never thought of doing.)

Saul was sick to death of who he had become. **Are we sick of who: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We are?
- Where we are?
- What we have become?

If so, we should repent and clear ourselves of all wrong doing! [Confession can be tough on the reputation but it's good for the soul.](#) Clearing ourselves is proof of repentance. (What can wash away my sin? Nothing but the blood of Jesus.)

Paul completely cleared himself before God. [Acts 9:11](#) (KJV) *“And the Lord said unto him, Arise, and go into the street which is called Straight, and enquire in the house of Judas for one called Saul, of Tarsus: for, behold, he prayeth.”* God said to Ananias, [Acts 9:15](#) (KJV) *“But the Lord said unto him, Go thy way: for he is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel.”* What a miracle! From public enemy number one to an Apostle in three short days. How? Paul said *“Yea what clearing of yourselves.”*

Have you ever carried a huge load of guilt so far that you couldn't go on? Have you ever wished there was someone you could tell? I have good news, you can tell it to Jesus, and he will help you clear yourself thus proving your repentance.

III. WHAT INDIGNATION...

[2 Corinthians 7:11](#) (KJV) *“For behold this selfsame thing, that ye sorrowed after a godly sort, what carefulness it wrought in you, yea, what clearing of yourselves, yea, what indignation...”* The word [indignation](#) as it is used here comes from the Greek word “*Agnaktesis*” (Ag-nak-te-sis), which [means to be greatly afflicted, to be sorely displeased.](#)

I want us to refer you once again to the definition of the word repentance; repentance comes from the Greek word “*Metanioa*” (Met-an-oy-a) meaning compunction for guilt including reformation. The word compunction means anxiety arising from the awareness of guilt. To reform means to amend or improve by change of form, or removal of faults or abuses.

Think about it. When we have sinned; the sin has been discovered; we have owned up to the offense and have made things right with God, others, and ourselves, proving that we are truly sorry; does this process not make us indignant or angry enough that we want to make sure we never repeat the offense again?

This world’s philosophy say’s: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Ignore the presence of sin...
- Do not allow the presence of sin upset you...
- Put the “failure” behind you...
- Move on with your life...
- Sin is no big deal...

The difference between the way God thinks and the thinking of the world is that sin is still a big deal in the sight of God. Sin was such a serious event that God sent his only begotten Son to die that it could be eradicated from the lives of those who would accept the blood sacrifice of Jesus as more than enough to

cover their sin. If God is that serious about sin, when it presents itself in our lives we should show a little indignation toward it as well.

In our text the Apostle Paul is attempting to communicate the message that if we have truly repented, we will prove it by showing enough indignation toward sin that we will voluntarily burn the sinful bridges behind us.

Simon Peter knew what indignation toward sin was all about. In the 26th chapter of Matthew Jesus tells His disciples that they will deny him. Knowing human nature as I know it, I am sure Jesus' words stirred a little indignation within the disciples. They probably thought of all the hardships they had endured with and for Jesus, and now he is saying they will deny him!

Notice what Peter says to Jesus in [Matthew 26:33](#) (KJV) “... *though all men shall be offended, yet will I never be offended.*” Peter is saying, the rest of these clowns may do what you have predicted, but you can count on me, I would never do a thing like that. (He is about to cause a little church trouble.)

Notice Jesus' response to Peter's words, “... *Verily I say unto thee, that this night, before the cock crow, thou shalt deny me thrice.*” I am assuming Peter became a little indignant here, based on his response. [Matthew 26:35](#) (KJV) “*Peter said unto him, though I should die with thee, yet will I not deny thee.* *Likewise also all the disciples.*” We know that Peter reacted just as Jesus had predicted! [Matthew 26:69-75](#) (KJV) “*Now Peter sat without in the palace: and a*

damsel came unto him, saying, Thou also wast with Jesus of Galilee. But he denied before them all saying, I know not what thou sayest. And when he was gone out into the porch, another maid saw him, and said unto them that were there, This fellow was also with Jesus of Nazareth. And again he denied with an oath, I do not know the man. And after a while came unto him they that stood by, and said to Peter, Surely thou also art one of them; for thy speech betrayed thee. Then began he to curse and to swear, saying, I know not the man." Just as Jesus had predicted, [Peter denied knowing Jesus three times before sun-up!](#)

Most of the time the story ends with the denial of Jesus by Peter and the disciples but notice this, *"... and immediately the cock crew. And Peter remembered the word of Jesus, which said unto him, before the cock crow, thou shalt deny me thrice."* The sound of that rooster crowing must have been the most horrible sound Peter had ever heard! As the sound of that rooster crowing reverberated through his mind, it began to stir him to repent, and also caused feelings of indignation toward his failure!

The Bible says Peter's response to his own sin was that *"... he went out, and wept bitterly."* The miracle here is that even though [Peter's](#) sin was exposed, he never once blames another disciple; he [took full and final responsibility for his own sin!](#)

Have you ever been totally disgusted with yourself because of sins and failures in your life? The person

who has given me the most problems in life is in this room this morning, and I am about to reveal who that person is! It is me!

We need to come back to the place where we realize that it's not my brother or my sister, but it's me o Lord, standing in the need of prayer!

How long has it been since you were angry because of your own failures? **When Holy indignation with our failures and sins becomes so pronounced that we are determined never to make that mistake again, the proof of repentance is beginning to manifest itself in our lives!**

IV. WHAT FEAR...

The word **fear** as it is used here, comes from the Greek word "*phobos*" (Fob'-os), which is derived from the word "*phebomai*" (Feb-om-i) which means **alarm or fright, or to be terrified!** This is where we get our English word phobia. Paul is saying that when our sin has been exposed, and we have truly repented, the proof of our repentance will be a holy terror of that particular sin!

This fear goes farther than just a healthy respect; it is an emotional event that manifests itself in a shying away from the tempting point of that particular sin!

I know that we are not to be living in fear. **2 Timothy (KJV) 1:7 "For God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind."** The fear we are to possess with regard to an

inherent weakness causes us to have such a horror of failure to the point that we do everything in our power to never fail to that particular weakness again. The thing that drives this fear in our lives is that we realize our sin has offended God. Though we are human beings who experience moments of weakness which could allow for failure in the future, the thought of such a failure should strike a cord of fear in our hearts with regard to our ability to fail!

When a person is afraid of something, he will stay as far away from it as possible. For example: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- I am afraid of snakes... I would never go to a Church that handles snakes! I am so afraid of snakes that I kill all snakes, good and bad snakes are all the same to me!
- I am afraid of heights... As a result I will not climb to the top of a skyscraper to look off! I stay as far from the edge as I possibly can!
- I am afraid of dogs... If I see a beware of dog's sign in a persons yard, they do not need to worry about me trespassing!

Why such a reaction to such simple things? Because I fear those things! They terrify me! Because they terrify me, I go out of my way to stay away from them!

Something that I found very interesting in doing the research for this message is that the word fear as it is used here, is not found in the Old Testament, but is actually used thirty two times in the New Testament! I

wondered why such a change from the Old Testament to the New Testament? Could it be that under the law there was not a great need to speak of the terror of the Lord because they witnessed it on a regular basis? However, under Grace, there is a constant need to remind the saints to fear failure because we have been introduced to such a kind, gentle, loving God.

While it is true that Jehovah is a God of all grace we must realize that He has taken a strong position against sin in the lives of His followers. If God takes such a strong position against sin His followers must do everything within their power to safeguard themselves against such a terribly evil thing. Paul makes this statement to the Philippian Christians in [Philippians 2:12-15](#) (KJV) *"Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling. For it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure. Do all things without murmurings and disputings: That ye may be blameless and harmless, the sons of God, without rebuke, in the midst of a crooked and perverse nation, among whom ye shine as lights in the world;"*

Notice with me the words of [2 Corinthians 7:1](#) (KJV) *"Having therefore these promises, dearly beloved, let us cleanse ourselves from all filthiness of the flesh and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God."*
[1 Peter 1:14-19](#) (KJV) *"As obedient children, not fashioning yourselves according to the former lusts in your ignorance;" "But as he which hath called you*

is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation;
16Because it is written, Be ye holy; for I am holy.
17And if ye call on the Father, who without respect
of persons judgeth according to every man's work,
pass the time of your sojourning here in fear:
18Forasmuch as ye know that ye were not redeemed
with corruptible things, as silver and gold, from
your vain conversation received by tradition from
your fathers; 19But with the precious blood of
Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without
spot:"

When Paul writes "*Yea what fear*" he is telling us there was a certain terror within of going back to his old ways! I believe it was the fear of allowing the old man to surface that caused Paul to live as far from failure as he did!

Those who fall into failure are the very ones who have failed to possess a healthy fear of failure which led to believing that sinful behavior was not really a big deal:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Samson...
- Judas...
- Demas...

Paul realized there were danger zones along the way! 1
Corinthians 9:24-27 (KJV) "Know ye not that they
which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the
prize? So run, that ye may obtain. 25 And every man
that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things.
Now they do it to obtain a corruptible crown; but we
an incorruptible. 26 I therefore so run, not as

uncertainly; so fight I, not as one that beateth the air: 27 But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway. "

When Satan has tripped us up a time or two and we have truly repented, we will be able to say with Paul, *"Yea what fear."* At this point *our repentance will be proven by the level of fear we exhibit toward our failure.*

We must come to the point that the question will not be, how close to the world can I live and still be a Christian, but what can I do to please Jesus, and keep from failing?

V. WHAT VEHEMENT DESIRE...

2 Corinthians 7:11 (KJV) *"... what vehement desire,"*

The word *vehement* as it is used here comes from the Greek word *epipothesis* (ep-ee-poth'-ay-sis), and *means a longing for, yearning, or intense craving.* The word *desire* comes from the same Greek word and means exactly the same thing.

It is believed that the writer here uses the same word twice, for emphasis sake. Think about it. Paul's sinful condition has been exposed through the conviction of the Holy Spirit, he has repented of his sin, and says that the proof of his repentance will be evidenced by what he longs for!

Paul seems to follow this same thought pattern when

he say's to the Colossian Christians in [Colossians. 3:1-3](#) (KJV) *"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God. Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth. For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God."* In this Scripture, [the word set has to do with reigning in the mind.](#) [The word affection has to do with controlling ones desires.](#) In other words Paul is saying, *If you have truly been born again, you will reign in your mind, control your thought process and by an act of your own will focus on spiritual things rather than carnal things."*

This is a concept which is completely foreign to this culture. The motto of our culture is *"If it fells good, do it!"* [The affects of this kind of shortsighted living is readily visible in this culture, as a result:](#) **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Our nation is in a state of total moral failure...](#)
(This week Fox news reported eleven year old girls being given birth control pills and keeping the whole thing a secret from the parents of the child!)
- [The electorate has become willing to ignore gross moral and ethical failures, as long as the economy is good...](#) (Some of whom are members of A/G Churches!)
- [Network television programming has become unfit for mature audiences, let alone children...](#)
(All the while Christians set watching with no conviction!)
- [Society is willing to condemn smoking, while](#)

legalizing marijuana, and excuse drunk driving... (While on a recent rafting trip down the Arkansas River in Colorado, our tour guide was adamant about telling all the guys on the trip not to urinate on a tree because such an act could potentially kill the tree, all the while he was smoking one cigarette after the other!)

- The population screams for more social programs to help the poor, and at the same time legalize gambling... (If you think gambling helps the schools and road systems, try taking a ride through Louisiana. The roads will beat the fillings out of your teeth and the schools are not fit for human habitation!)
- The system will imprison a person who kills an animal out of season or violates a green law while setting free murderers, rapists, and child molesters...
- This culture is extremely careful about keeping church and state separate, railing against Biblical values while accepting as normal the sins of adultery, fornication, and homosexuality... (Same sex marriages are a misnomer, it is perversion at its worst and the Bible calls them whoremongers and sodomites who are living a lifestyle which is totally out of control! Rosie O'Donnell was applauded for stating the "*Fundamentalists Christians are as dangerous as radical Islamists!*" Proof that Rosie is absolutely wrong is the fact that she is still breathing good air! If she had lived in an Islamic country she would have been taken out for using Islam and Christian in the same

sentence!)

The sad thing is that the Church as a whole is not much better off than the world! It is difficult to distinguish between Christians and non Christians! The church has been neutered by the world and we have bought into a philosophy of *"Everyone is going to make it, God wouldn't send anyone to hell!"*

Paul's message is the word which needs to be heard by the 21st century church. His message is simple; If we have truly repented we will reign in our carnal mind as well as our maverick nature and will force, if necessary, our desires to change.

The Christian life is not a path to be chosen by the faint hearted, it takes vehement desire to follow Jesus!

Look at what the Word has to say about our desires and what we are to do with them! [Colossians 3:5-10](#)

(KJV) ***"Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry.***

Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. You used to walk in these ways, in the life you once lived.

But now you must rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. Do not lie to each other,

since you have taken off your old self with its practices and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its

Creator." [1 Peter 2:11](#) (KJV) ***"Dear friends, I urge***

you, as aliens and strangers in the world, to abstain from sinful desires, which war against your soul."

Jesus himself said, [Matthew 16:24](#) (KJV) *"Then Jesus said to his disciples, "If anyone would come after me, he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow me."* Notice three things here: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Self denial...** This is simply saying NO to oneself!
- **Cross bearing...** The cross is an instrument of capital punishment!
- **Follow-ship...** Our theme song must become *"Where he leads, I will follow."*

This is not an exercise recommended for the spiritually anemic; it takes vehement desire to follow Jesus.

From the day on the road to Damascus, to the end of his earthly journey, it is a proven fact that Paul had a vehement desire to follow Jesus and to do the will of God. We assume that this radical change was easy street for him, but notice what he says to the Roman Christians in [Romans 7:23-25](#) (KJV) *"But I see another law at work in the members of my body, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within my members. 24 What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death? 25 Thanks be to God—through Jesus Christ our Lord! So then, I myself in my mind am a slave to God's law, but in the sinful nature a slave to the law of sin. "*

Proving repentance will be no easier for us than it was for Paul, but it is a do-able task. Notice with me again, [Colossians 3:2-3](#) (KJV) *"Set your minds on things*

above, not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God. " The key to setting our affections and proving our repentance is getting our heart in the right place! How do we know when our heart is in the right place? *Our heart is in the right place when we would rather: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)*

- Edify, than gossip...
- Smile, than frown...
- Go to church, than stay home...
- Pray than fellowship...
- Read our Bible, than read the newspaper...
- Work for God, than to work for ourselves...
- Pay our tithes, than to pay the bills...
- Submit to authority, than have our way...
- Stay married, than to divorce...
- Overcome sin, than to fall into sin...

How is it possible to always have vehement desire for the things of God? Jesus himself said, in [Luke 12:34 \(KJV\)](#) ***"For where your treasure is there your heart will be also."*** The heart is the seat of our emotions! So what he is saying here is that *we will be passionate in the area that we have chosen for our heart to dwell.* The key to setting our affections and proving our repentance is getting our heart in the right place!

VI. WHAT ZEAL...

The word zeal comes from the Greek word *zelos* (zay'-los), and means ardor. The word ardor means, (1) Emotional -warmth; passion. (2) Enthusiasm. (3) Intense heat; fire.

The term zeal is different than the term, vehement desire. Vehement desire allows for us to get our focus back to where it should have been, and enables us to set our affections in the proper place, and on the proper things. The [zeal](#) spoken of here [causes us to create a plan of action that will lead to the revenge that we will talk about later.](#)

While Paul, who was then Saul, was on Straight Street he began to realize the awfulness of what he had been involved in. Sometime during this three day rendezvous with God, it began to dawn on Paul that if he was going to leave there a different kind of person he had to form a plan of attack against the flesh, and against Satan!

Some people seem to believe that God brain washed Paul with His search light from heaven, and he just woke up in another world, as a different kind of person! Sure there were some things in Paul's life that God did change, but there were many more that Paul himself was going to need to change!

How is it possible to change ones life? Someone said [“People can change, but not much.”](#) This appears to be a pretty pessimistic point of view, but without the help of the Holy Spirit it is a pretty realistic point of view.

The only way any of us can hope to make major life changes is through repentance. Contrary to the opinions of the majority of folks who actually believe

God can make such changes in us, God is not going to come down and hold a gun to our heads and make sure we change some things in our lives. Some people say, *“When God gets ready for me to quit this habit he will take away the desire.”*

The truly repentant will discover they have adequate zeal to choose a plan of action that will guarantee success! **Zeal is the emotional motivation that drives the process of change.** Zeal is the power source of our desire to be different! The proof of repentance is having adequate zeal to make the changes!

Pentecostals are really good at being stirred:

- We cry...
- We clap...
- We jump...
- We shout...
- We laugh...
- We dance...

There is nothing inherently wrong with any of these things, in fact I encourage them, I think **we should be emotional concerning the most epic event in our lives** but what I want to know is, when the emotions have dried up, in what way have we been changed?

God is not nearly as interested in how emotional you have become, what He wants to know is that after the emotion has drained out of the service and sermon, are we still motivated enough to change? Anybody can cry! If you don't believe it come up here and let me see if I can unstop your tear ducts by hitting your

thumb with a hammer!

The answer to the whole thing is being sorry enough for our sin that we have engaged in true repentance which will produce enough zeal to develop a successful plan of attack against our old sinful nature!

Let us take a moment to discover [Paul's plan of attack against the old nature](#) following the three day rendezvous with God on Straight Street: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Die to sin and self...](#) Galatians 2:20 (KJV) "*I am crucified with Christ; nevertheless I live; yet not I but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me., and gave himself for me.*" Some believe that Paul wrote the book of Hebrews, and I too believe he did, but whoever did certainly spoke out clearly on this subject. [Hebrews 12:1-2](#) (KJV) "*Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us, Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith; who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is set down at the right hand of the throne of God.*"
- [Live as close to God as possible...](#) Philippians 3:4-9 (KJV) "*Though I might also have confidence in the flesh. If any other man thinketh that he hath whereof he might trust*

in the flesh, I more: Circumcised the eighth day, of the stock of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, an Hebrew of the Hebrews; as touching the law, a Pharisee; Concerning zeal, persecuting the church; touching the righteousness which is in the law, blameless. But what things were gain to me, those I counted loss for Christ. Yea doubtless, and I count all things but loss for the Excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord: for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and do count them but dung, that I may win Christ, And be found in him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ, the righteousness which is of God by faith:"

- Know everything there is to know about God...
 Philippians 3:10-16 (KJV) "That I may know him, and the power of his resurrection, and the fellowship of his sufferings, being made conformable unto his death; If by any means I might attain unto the resurrection of the dead. Not as though I had already attained, either were already perfect: but I follow after, if that I may apprehend that for which also I am apprehended of Christ Jesus. Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended: but this one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before, I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus. Let us therefore, as many as be perfect, be thus minded: and if in

any thing ye be otherwise minded, God shall reveal even this unto you. Nevertheless, whereto we have already attained, let us walk by the same rule, let us mind the same thing. "

- *Finish strong... 2 Timothy 4:6-8 (KJV) "For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand. I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing."*

Many years ago I played golf with a man in my church who would beat me every time and when I would out-drive him he would say, "It's not how you drive, its how you arrive."

The thing that made Paul such a success with God is that he truly repented and the proof of his repentance is the fact, his zeal established a plan of attack against failure!

If you and I are going to be successful in this good fight of the faith, we must do exactly the same thing!

VII. WHAT REVENGE...

The word *revenge* as it is used here, comes from the Greek word "*ekdikesis*" (ek-dik'-ay-sis) and means *vindication, or retribution*. To vindicate means:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- To clear from criticism, blame, or suspicion...

- To defend against opposition...
- To justify...

The word retribution means, punishment for evil done, or reward for good done!

I realize there is great danger in what I am about to share with you today, some people would like to take a sermon on revenge, and use it against someone in their family, a coworker, an employee, or an employer. The Word of God speaks out very strongly about taking revenge against our fellow man. Leviticus 19:18

(KJV) "Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people, but thou shalt love thy neighbor as thyself: I am the Lord." Matthew

5:39 (KJV) "But I say unto you, That ye resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also." 1 Peter 3:8-9

(KJV) "Finally, be ye all of one mind, having compassion one of another, love as brethren, be pitiful, be courteous: Not rendering evil for evil, or railing for railing: but contrariwise blessing; knowing that ye are thereunto called, that ye should inherit a blessing."

Even though we are not to ever take revenge on another human being, we have been given permission by our Heavenly Father to take revenge on the enemy!

Following Paul's three day rendezvous with God on Straight Street he began immediately taking revenge on the enemy, and never let up until the final breath had been drawn. Before conversion, Paul by his own admission was the chief of sinners; he was a very

valuable tool in the hands of the enemy. When he was converted, he made up his mind to be at least as good a Christian as he was a sinner. Let us take some time and look at the revenge Paul took against the enemy!

The Church at Antioch, inspired by the Holy Spirit ordained Paul and Barnabas for missionary service, and sent John Mark with them. From this launching pad Paul was instrumental in preaching the Gospel all over the world, and establishing Churches in places that had never heard the Gospel of Christ before. As you are well aware, Paul wrote much of the New Testament, thus, more than 2,000 years later he is still getting his revenge on the enemy through this sermon.

The problem with many modern day Christians is that we have become so lethargic that we don't have enough spiritual adrenaline to cause us to go to Church three times a week, let alone take revenge on the enemy! We have certainly been given the weapons necessary, to do damage against the kingdom of darkness. Ephesians 6:10-18 (KJV) *"Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord, and in the power of his might. Put on the whole armour of God that ye may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil. For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places. Wherefore take unto you the whole armour of God that ye may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand. Stand therefore, having your loins girt about with truth, and having on the breastplate of*

righteousness; And your feet shod with the preparation of the gospel of peace; Above all, taking the shield of faith, wherewith ye shall be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked. And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God: Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints." 2 Corinthians 10:3-6 (KJV) "For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war after the flesh: (For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strong holds ;) Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ; And having in a readiness to revenge all disobedience, when your obedience is fulfilled."

Some people are afraid to attempt to carry out a plan of revenge against the enemy, because they believe he is stronger than they are. All power has been given to Christ! Matthew 28:18 (KJV) "*And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, all power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.*" If you are a blood bought child of God, you are stronger and more powerful, than the devil! Luke 10:19 (KJV) "*Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy: and nothing shall by any means hurt you.*" 1 Corinthians 10:13 (KJV) "*There hath no temptation taken you but such as is common to man: but God is faithful, who will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are*

able; but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that ye may be able to bear it." James 4:7 (KJV) "Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you." Romans 16:20 (KJV) "And the God of peace shall bruise Satan under your feet shortly. The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you. Amen."

Go ahead! Step out there and take sweet revenge on the enemy until you can say with Paul, *"Yea, what revenge..."*

VIII. IN ALL THINGS YOU HAVE APPROVED YOURSELVES TO BE CLEAR IN THIS MATTER...

We have thoroughly addressed all seven aspects of Paul's discourse on repentance. He quickly moves from speaking on the proof of repentance to making a statement which does not seem to fit. 2 Corinthians 7:11 (KJV) *"... In all things ye have approved yourselves to be clear in this matter."* There are two very important words in verse eleven: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The word **approved** comes from the Greek word, *"sunistao"* (soon-is-tah'-o) and figuratively **means to exhibit**.
- The word **clear** comes from the Greek word "hagnos" (hag-nos') and **means to be clean, perfect, or pure**. In a figurative sense it means innocent.

In other words Paul is saying that through the seven proofs of repentance you have exhibited that you are

innocent in this matter! We are innocent of what? You will recall that we began this series of sermons by talking about the letter Paul had written to this Church that might have initially stirred up some emotions of anger, but eventually led to Godly sorrow which produced proof of repentance.

In order that we might understand what the Corinthian Church is being deemed innocent of, we must first look at what Paul had charged them with: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Divisions in the Church...
- The absence of discipline in the Church...
- Civil litigation between members of the body of Christ...
- The moral decline of members of the Church...
- Willingness to treat marriage as something less than a covenant...
- The eating of food sacrificed to idols...

Paul laid out some pretty stiff and serious charges against the Corinthian Church! I wonder what the charges would be against some of us?

Paul used 15 chapters, 447 verses to lay out the charges, and then he says ***“In all things you have exhibited that you are innocent in this matter.”***

Think of it, all the trouble to bring all these charges, then the prosecution asks for an innocent verdict! Is that not a little frustrating and disappointing? How could a thing like that happen? These are serious charges!

Here is how it happened: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- They were guilty as charged to begin with...
- Paul's charges against them caused them to sorrow to repentance...
- Their repentance was proven by their attitudes, actions, and conduct...
- Because of their repentance and the proof of their repentance they were found innocent of all charges...

Now this thing would be treated as if it never happened!

CONCLUSION: The same things happen with us!
We have been formally charged by the Word of God!
We are guilty! The charges have us dead to rights!

Jesus has paid the price for our pardon and redemption! Isaiah 55:7 (KJV) *"Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: And let him return unto the Lord, and he will have mercy upon him; and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon."* 1 John 1:9 (KJV) *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."*

The only thing remaining is for us to plead guilty to all charges, sorrow to repentance, and prove our repentance through our lifestyles! When this has been done, notice the results! Psalm 130:4 (KJV) *"But there is forgiveness with thee, that thou mayest be*

feared." Psalm 103:1-3 (KJV) "Bless the Lord, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name. 2Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: 3Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases;" Ephesians 1:3-7 (KJV) "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ: 4According as he hath chosen us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before him in love: 5Having predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the good pleasure of his will, 6To the praise of the glory of his grace, wherein he hath made us accepted in the beloved. 7In whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace;" Psalm 103:12 (KJV) "As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us."

When I was a child growing up in a Pentecostal Church a song was sang quite often that simply say's:
"You ask me why I'm happy so I'll just tell you why, because my sins are gone; And when I meet the scoffers who ask me where they are, I say, my sins are gone.

'Twas at the old time altar where God came in my heart and now, my sins are gone; The Lord took full possession, the devil did depart, I'm glad my sins are gone.

When satan comes to tempt me and tries to make me

doubt, I say, my sins are gone; You got me into trouble, but Jesus got me out, I'm glad my sins are gone.

I'm living now for Jesus, I'm happy night and day, because my sins are gone; My soul is filled with music, with all my heart I say, I know my sins are gone.

CHORUS:

They're underneath the Blood on the Cross of Calvary, as far removed as darkness is from dawn; in the sea of God's forgetfulness that's good enough for me. Praise God, my sins are gone."

Someone said, "When God forgave me he cast my sins in the sea of his forgetfulness, and then put up a sign that say's 'No Fishing.'"

"In all things you have approved yourselves to be clear in this matter."